



MINDFUL DIABETES FREE GUIDES

Simple, practical guidance for metabolic and brain health.

The Mindful Plate

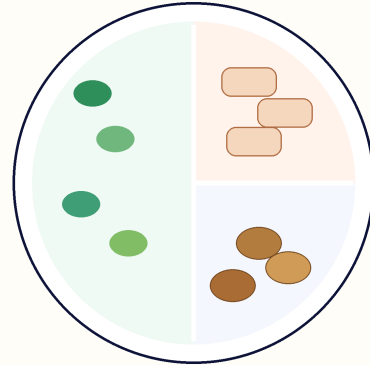
A Simple Guide to Blood Sugar-Friendly Eating

FREE GUIDE

Mindful Diabetes Free Guides

The Mindful Plate

A simple guide to blood sugar-friendly eating



FREE GUIDE

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WELCOME

A calmer way to build a meal

If food advice has started to feel like a stack of rules, this guide is meant to lower the noise. The Mindful Plate is a flexible way to assemble meals that include vegetables, protein, carbohydrate, and flavor without weighing everything or giving up foods that matter to you.

It is written for adults with type 2 diabetes, prediabetes, a family history of diabetes, or an interest in metabolic and brain health. Caregivers and family members may also find it useful.

This guide can help with

Building balanced meals, reading your plate more clearly, choosing drinks with less added sugar, and planning a few realistic meals for the week.

This guide cannot replace

Medical nutrition therapy, medication advice, glucose targets, insulin adjustment, pregnancy care, eating-disorder care, kidney-disease guidance, or urgent medical attention.

A useful plate is not a perfect plate

Some meals are mixed together in a bowl. Some come from a restaurant. Some are leftovers eaten between responsibilities. That is real life. Use this method as a starting point, then adapt it with your clinician or dietitian if you have specific needs.



QUICK START

Start here tonight

- Choose one meal, not your whole life.
- Fill about half the plate with non-starchy vegetables if you have them.
- Add a protein food such as eggs, chicken, fish, tofu, beans, yogurt, or lean meat.
- Choose one carbohydrate food such as rice, oats, bread, potato, fruit, lentils, or tortilla.
- Pick water, unsweet tea, or another drink that does not add much sugar.
- Notice how you feel afterward. If you check glucose, follow the plan your care team gave you.

No all-or-nothing test

If half the plate is not possible, add one vegetable side. If dinner is pizza, add a salad or vegetables and use the next meal as another chance.

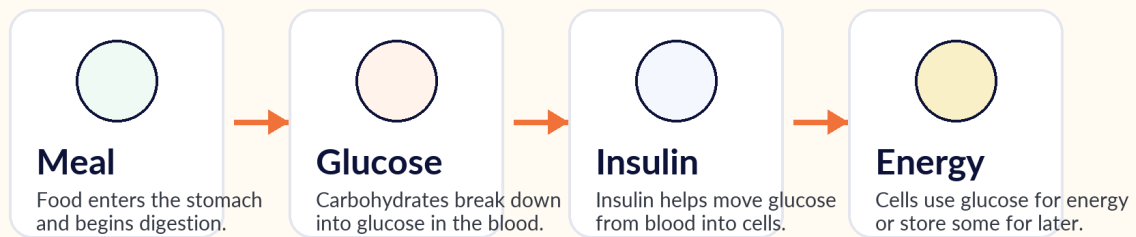
Contents

- 4 What happens after we eat?
- 5 The Mindful Plate method
- 6-9 Carbohydrates, protein, fiber, and fat
- 10-13 Breakfast, lunch, dinner, and snacks
- 14-16 Drinks, portions, and sample menus
- 17-20 Worksheets, grocery list, questions, references



FOOD AND BLOOD SUGAR

What happens after we eat?



The speed and size of the rise can be affected by the food, portion, fiber, protein, fat, timing

During digestion, the body breaks food into smaller parts. Carbohydrate foods usually have the most direct effect on blood glucose because many carbohydrates break down into glucose. Insulin is a hormone that helps move glucose from the blood into cells so it can be used for energy. [1]

That does not mean carbohydrates are the only thing that matters. Protein, fiber, fat, the size of the portion, timing, activity, illness, stress, sleep, alcohol, and medicines can all influence glucose patterns. Two people can eat a similar meal and see different results.

Safety note

Do not change insulin, diabetes medicine, or glucose targets because of this guide. If your readings are often high or low, ask your care team what changes are safest for you.

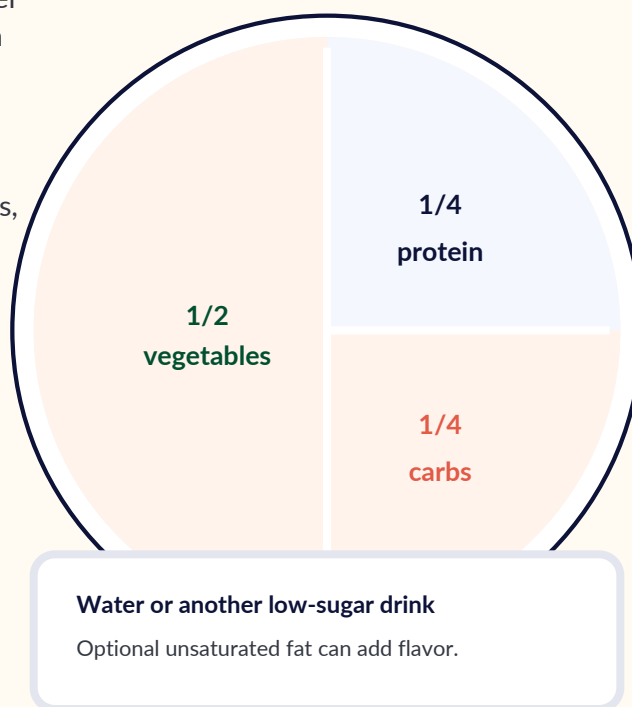


THE METHOD

The Mindful Plate

The plate method is a simple visual approach. A common diabetes plate pattern uses about one-half non-starchy vegetables, one-quarter protein, and one-quarter carbohydrate, with water or another low-calorie drink. [2]

This guide uses that pattern as a flexible starting point. It can work with many food traditions: rice and beans, dal and vegetables, tacos, stir-fries, soups, sandwiches, Mediterranean meals, Caribbean plates, or leftovers.



What this does not mean

It does not mean every meal must look separated on a plate. Mixed dishes can still be balanced by thinking about what is inside them and what you serve alongside them.



CARBOHYDRATES

Carbs without confusion

Grains

rice, oats, pasta,
bread, tortillas

Starchy vegetables

potatoes, corn,
peas, plantains

Fruit

berries, apples,
bananas, oranges

Milk/yogurt

milk, plain yogurt,
kefir

Beans/lentils

black beans,
chickpeas, dal

Sweets/drinks

soda, candy,
sweet tea, desserts

Carbohydrates are found in grains, starchy vegetables, fruit, milk, yogurt, beans, lentils, sweets, and sugary drinks. They are not automatically forbidden. The type, amount, and what you eat with them matter.

A helpful pattern is to pair carbohydrate foods with protein, fiber-rich foods, and vegetables when possible. For example, rice with beans and vegetables is different from rice alone. Oatmeal with nuts and berries is different from sweetened cereal and juice.

Try this

Choose one carbohydrate you eat often. Keep the food, but experiment with the portion and what you pair it with.



PROTEIN

Protein helps a meal hold together

Protein foods can support fullness and help make a meal feel more steady. They may come from animal or plant sources: eggs, fish, chicken, turkey, lean meats, tofu, tempeh, edamame, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, beans, lentils, and nuts or seeds.

Budget-friendly options

- Canned tuna or salmon, if it fits your budget and preferences.
- Eggs, which can work at breakfast, lunch, or dinner.
- Dried or canned beans and lentils. Rinse canned beans to lower sodium.
- Plain yogurt bought in a larger container instead of single sweetened cups.
- Frozen fish or chicken when fresh options are expensive.

Beans count in two places

Beans and lentils contain protein and carbohydrate. They can still fit beautifully. Pair them with vegetables and consider the rest of the meal.



FIBER

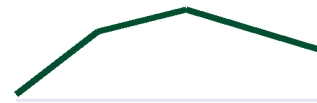
Fiber is quiet but powerful

Lower-fiber meal



May digest faster
for some people.

Higher-fiber meal



Often slows digestion
and supports fullness.

Fiber is a type of carbohydrate the body does not fully digest. Many fiber-rich foods can help with fullness, bowel regularity, cholesterol patterns, and steadier meals. The FDA Daily Value for fiber is 28 grams per day based on a 2,000-calorie diet, but individual needs vary. [3]

Add fiber gradually. A sudden jump from very little fiber to a lot can cause gas, bloating, or discomfort. Fluids matter too. People with digestive disease, kidney disease, swallowing problems, or certain medical diets should ask for individualized guidance.



DIETARY FAT

Fat adds flavor, texture, and staying power

Dietary fat is an essential nutrient. It helps with cell function, flavor, satisfaction, and absorption of some vitamins. The type and food source matter. A heart-health pattern usually emphasizes unsaturated fats from foods such as nuts, seeds, avocado, fish, and non-tropical liquid plant oils, while limiting saturated fat and avoiding trans fat. [7]

Small amounts can go a long way

- Add avocado or nuts to a meal that needs staying power.
- Use olive, canola, soybean, or other non-tropical liquid oils when they fit the recipe.
- Choose fried foods and high-saturated-fat foods less often if heart health is a concern.
- If you have cholesterol, kidney, liver, or digestive concerns, ask your care team what fits you.

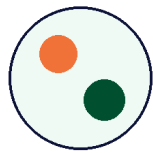
More detail coming

This guide gives only the basics. The companion guide *Fats Without Fear* will explain saturated, unsaturated, and trans fats in plain language.



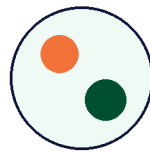
EXAMPLES

Breakfasts, if breakfast fits your day



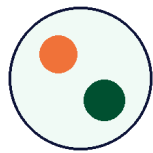
Eggs + toast + vegetable

eggs, greens, whole-grain toast



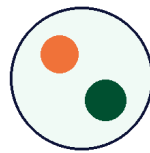
Yogurt bowl

plain yogurt, berries, nuts, oats



Oatmeal

oats, chia, fruit, nut butter



Beans + tortilla

beans, egg, salsa, corn tortilla

Not everyone wants or needs breakfast. If you do eat it, breakfast can be a useful place to add protein, fiber, and a lower-sugar drink.

- Eggs, whole-grain toast, sauteed greens, and tomato.
- Plain yogurt with berries, nuts, and a small amount of oats.
- Oatmeal with chia or ground flax, fruit, and nut butter.
- Beans, egg or tofu, salsa, vegetables, and a corn tortilla.



EXAMPLES

Lunches that do not require a fresh start

Lunch often happens between work, caregiving, school, appointments, or errands. It does not need to be a recipe. Think in pieces: something colorful, something protein-rich, something with fiber, and something you enjoy.

Flexible lunch ideas

- Bowl: greens, leftover chicken or tofu, beans, salsa, and brown rice or quinoa.
- Sandwich: whole-grain bread, turkey or hummus, vegetables, and fruit on the side.
- Soup: lentil, bean, chicken vegetable, or minestrone, plus salad if available.
- No-cook: tuna packet, whole-grain crackers, cucumber, carrots, and fruit.
- Leftovers: add a vegetable side or a handful of greens to yesterday's dinner.

Restaurant note

If lunch is ordered out, look for one adjustment: add vegetables, choose water, share fries, or save part for later. One useful change is enough.



EXAMPLES

Dinners can honor culture and still be balanced

Healthy eating should not erase family food. Many traditional meals already include the pieces we are looking for: vegetables, beans, lentils, fish, lean meats, yogurt, grains, herbs, spices, and shared routines.

- Tacos: beans or grilled chicken, cabbage, salsa, avocado, and corn tortillas.
- Dal: lentils with vegetables, cucumber salad, and a smaller scoop of rice if needed.
- Stir-fry: tofu, chicken, shrimp, or beef with mixed vegetables and rice.
- Mediterranean plate: fish, salad, roasted vegetables, hummus, and pita.
- Caribbean-inspired plate: stewed chicken or fish, greens, beans, and plantain.
- Pasta night: pasta with vegetables, tomato sauce, beans or lean protein, and salad.

The portion and the pattern matter

No single food has to carry the whole meal. A higher-carb food can often fit better when the rest of the plate supports it.



SNACKS

Snacks are optional

Some people feel better with planned snacks. Others do not need them. Snacks may be useful if meals are far apart, activity changes your glucose, medication timing matters, or hunger makes the next meal harder to manage.

Protein plus fiber snack ideas

- Apple slices with peanut butter.
- Plain yogurt with berries.
- Hummus with carrots, cucumbers, or whole-grain crackers.
- A boiled egg with fruit.
- Edamame or roasted chickpeas.
- Nuts with a small piece of fruit.

Medication safety

If you use insulin or medicines that can cause low blood sugar, ask your care team how snacks, activity, and low readings should be handled.



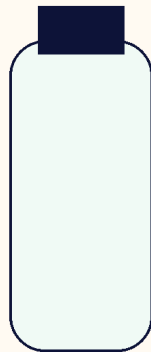
DRINKS

Drinks and hidden sugars



Water

0 g carbs



Unsweet tea

0 g carbs



Milk

check label



Juice

can add up fast



Soda

high added sugar

A drink does not need to be perfect. Start by improving one drink you have often.

Sugary drinks can raise blood glucose quickly because they are easy to drink fast and do not bring much fiber or fullness. Soda, sweet tea, juice, energy drinks, sports drinks, and sweet coffee drinks can all add sugar quickly.

The FDA Daily Value for added sugars is 50 grams per day based on a 2,000-calorie diet. The Dietary Guidelines recommend limiting added sugars to less than 10 percent of daily calories. [4]

Try this

Pick one drink you have often and make one change: smaller size, less syrup, unsweet tea, sparkling water, infused water, or water beside the drink.



PORTIONS

Portions without weighing everything

Portions do not need to be exact to be useful. The plate method gives a visual estimate. Labels give serving sizes. Cups, bowls, and hand-based estimates can help when measuring is not realistic.

Helpful rough estimates

- A fist can be a rough estimate for about one cup of some foods.
- A palm can be a rough estimate for a portion of cooked meat, poultry, fish, tofu, or tempeh.
- A thumb can be a rough estimate for a small amount of oil, nut butter, or dressing.
- A label serving size is not a personalized recommendation. It is the amount used for the numbers on the label. [3]

Keep it kind

Portion awareness is a tool, not a judgment. If measuring food feels stressful or unsafe for you, ask for support from a clinician or dietitian.



SAMPLE MENU

Three days of flexible ideas

Day 1

Yogurt bowl | Bean and vegetable soup | Fish, greens, rice | Apple with peanut butter

Day 2

Eggs and toast | Turkey or hummus sandwich | Chicken or tofu stir-fry | Yogurt or nuts

Day 3

Oatmeal with seeds | Leftover bowl | Dal, salad, and rice | Carrots with hummus

These are examples, not a prescription. Your calorie, carbohydrate, protein, sodium, kidney, allergy, pregnancy, medication, and glucose needs may be different.

Vegetarian swap

Use beans, lentils, tofu, tempeh, edamame, eggs, yogurt, nuts, and seeds in patterns that fit your food traditions and medical needs.



PRINTABLE WORKSHEET

Build your own meal

How to use it

Choose one meal you already eat. Write down what you could add, reduce, swap, or prepare ahead. Keep the change small enough that you can actually try it.

1/2 plate vegetables

1/4 plate protein

1/4 plate carbohydrate

Drink

Flavor or fat

What I can prep ahead



SHOPPING

Grocery starter list

Vegetables

greens, carrots, peppers, broccoli, cabbage, frozen mixed vegetables

Fruit

berries, apples, oranges, bananas, peaches, frozen fruit

Protein

eggs, fish, chicken, tofu, yogurt, beans, lentils, tuna

Carbs

oats, brown rice, tortillas, potatoes, whole-grain bread, quinoa

Fats

olive or canola oil, nuts, seeds, avocado, nut butter

Flavor

garlic, herbs, spices, salsa, vinegar, lemon, low-sodium broth

Budget note

Frozen, canned, dried, and store-brand foods can be practical. Rinse canned beans or vegetables when you want less sodium.



QUESTIONS AND MYTHS

A few food questions people ask all the time

Do I have to stop eating carbohydrates?

No. Many people do better by choosing portions and pairings that fit their plan.

Is fruit too sugary?

Whole fruit brings water, fiber, vitamins, and flavor. Portion and individual response still matter.

Is brown sugar healthier?

Brown sugar is still added sugar. It may taste different, but it is not a blood sugar workaround.

Are potatoes forbidden?

No. Think about portion, preparation, and the rest of the meal.

Do I have to buy expensive health foods?

No. Beans, oats, frozen vegetables, eggs, canned fish, and plain yogurt can be useful basics.

Can I keep culturally important foods?

Yes. The goal is to adapt patterns, not erase identity.



NEXT STEPS

Keep the guide useful

Pick one page to use this week. You might build one balanced dinner, improve one drink, or complete the meal worksheet. If you track glucose, compare changes only in the way your care team recommends.

Mindful Diabetes resources

[Explore the Guide](#)

[Visit Health Tools](#)

[Try JEIR](#)

[Support free health education](#)

This guide is for general education only. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Individual nutrition needs vary. Do not change medication, insulin, or glucose targets based on this guide. Seek appropriate medical attention for severe low blood sugar, severe high blood sugar, sudden confusion, chest pain, trouble breathing, fainting, seizures, or other urgent symptoms.

Medical disclaimer

References

- [1] American Diabetes Association. Standards of Care in Diabetes - 2026. 2026.
- [2] American Diabetes Association Nutrition & Wellness Team. What is the Diabetes Plate?. 2026.
- [3] U.S. Food and Drug Administration. How to Understand and Use the Nutrition Facts Label. 2024.
- [4] U.S. Food and Drug Administration. Added Sugars on the Nutrition Facts Label. 2026.
- [5] Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. What Is the National Diabetes Prevention Program?. 2024.
- [6] Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Your Brain and Diabetes. 2024.
- [7] American Heart Association. Fats in Foods. 2026.
- [8] American Heart Association. Saturated Fats. 2024.

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